share of its Muslim-Yadav base.

The overall vote share of the two alliances further illustrates this shift. In 2019, when the NDA secured 39 of Bihar's 40 Lok Sabha seats, the gap between the vote shares of the NDA and the Mahagathbandhan (MGB) was over 21 percentage points. In 2024, with the NDA bagging 47.2 per cent against the MGB's 36.5 per cent, the gap remains significant but is clearly narrowing.

In his campaign, Tejaswi drew large crowds across Bihar. His narrative—again centred around jobs and economic justice—resonated widely, but he still has to reckon with the gap of over 10 percentage points between the two alliances. Of course, that does not fully take into account all the coalition dynamics Bihar witnessed in a remarkable five years since the last assembly election, with Nitish changing sides twice. The longevity of the present arrangement, too, has seemed less than rock-solid; it is clearly mutual convenience rather than blind love that keeps the JD(U)-BJP together. But that contract seems good enough to impose some curbs on the RJD's growth path in the near term.

THOUGH RJD SECURED ONLY FOUR LS SEATS, IT GARNERED AN IMPRESSIVE 9.6 MILLION VOTES

A scrutiny of the LS seatwise results throws up good news and warning signs for the RJD, says Nalin Verma, faculty at the Jamia Hamdard University in Delhi and co-author of Lalu's autobiography *Gopalganj to Raisina*. "The good news is, Tejaswi has managed to expand his party's support base. Leveraging his aspirational appeal, he has made some inroads into the peripheral OBC/ EBC voter base. But he has yet to capture a significant portion of the numerically crucial *ati pichhada* (extremely backward) vote, which remains loyal to Nitish." There will soon come a time when these vote blocs will be more mobile, but Tejaswi is a young man in a hurry. ■



AFP

MAHARASHTRA

A SAFE HOME FOR JUMBOS

By Dhaval S. Kulkarni

In the forests of eastern Maharashtra, a new chapter in India's conservation story is unfolding. The state, otherwise known for its tigers and leopards, is grappling with an unexpected arrival: a herd of wild elephants that has made the region its home. The migration could very well lead to the creation of the state's first elephant reserve. If all comes to fruition, Maharashtra can trumpet about a 1,416.6 sq. km protected area spanning sections of the Nawegaon Nagzira Tiger Reserve (NNTR)—home to about a dozen big cats—besides parts of the Gadchiroli, Gondia and Wadsa territorial forest divisions in the Vidarbha region.

The elephants first crossed into Maharashtra from neighbouring Chhattisgarh in October 2021, says a state forest department official. After a brief sojourn, they returned, only to come back in 2022. Since then, about 27 elephants, including a herd and a lone tusker, have been roaming in the region, bringing along both wonder and worry. For, in search of food, the elephants have taken to raiding paddy and maize fields and even demolishing thatched houses. In the past three years, the forest department has paid out nearly Rs 3 crore in compensation for crop and property damage in Gadchiroli alone.